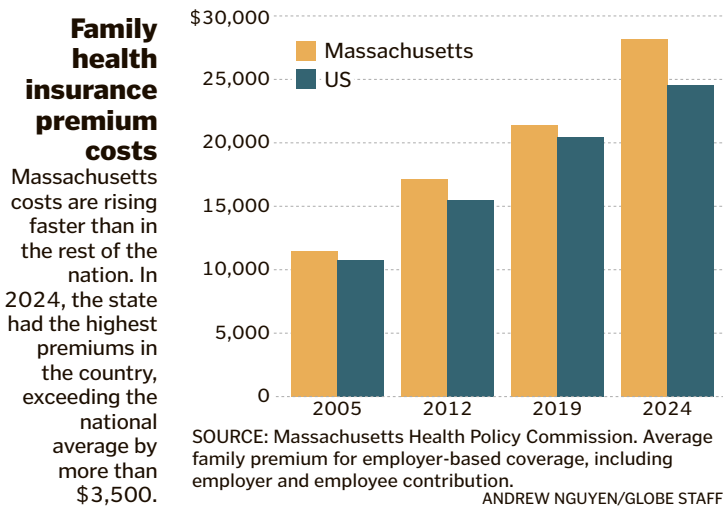


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THURSDAY, DECEMBER 4, 2025

Rising health insurance costs take toll



Families, businesses are forced to make hard choices

By Jessica Bartlett and Marin Wolf
GLOBE STAFF

Each time one of Tamara Modig's children needs a telehealth appointment, she boots up a fragile 13-year-old laptop and prays it'll hold a charge.

Then Modig is forced to fret over another concern: the cost of health care.

The Fitchburg Public Schools employee and her husband pay more than \$9,300 annually in health insurance pre-

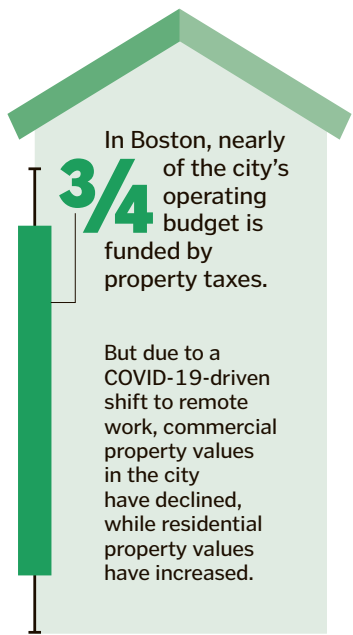
miums for their family of five. It's already a substantial chunk of their combined \$160,000 income.

Modig knows it's almost certainly going to rise next year, though she won't learn how much until spring. Already, her out-of-pocket maximum this past year increased by \$1,000, to \$4,000. The family doesn't take vacations, drives only used cars, and lives on a strict budget — which is about to get even stricter.

"You wonder if you can make that pair of shoes last longer," Modig said. "Does last year's coat still fit the kids?"

The rising price of health insurance has become top of mind in many households across the state as families like the Modigs take stock during traditional open enrollment periods. Many employers' premiums have risen by 10 percent or more, insurers and brokers say, straining families' budgets.

HEALTH INSURANCE, Page A7



Reed turns up heat on US boat strikes

R.I. senator takes issue with 'reality show'

By Jim Puzzanghera
GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — The US military strike on a speedboat allegedly containing drug traffickers off the Venezuela coast in September raised red flags for Rhode Island Senator Jack Reed immediately.

"There is no evidence — none — that this strike was conducted in self-defense," the West Point graduate and former Army Ranger declared in a speech on the Senate floor a few days later. "That matters, because under both domestic and international law, the US military simply does not have the authority to use lethal force against a civilian vessel unless acting in self-defense."

Now, Reed worries his worst fears about the deadly attacks in the Caribbean have been realized.

After a Washington Post report that a second strike during the September mission killed two survivors clinging to the wreckage, Reed, the top Democrat on the Senate Armed Services Committee, said he was "concerned."

REED, Page A6

Israel said it would begin allowing some Palestinians to leave the Gaza Strip for Egypt "in the coming days" through the Rafah border crossing. **A3.**

Mass General Brigham wants to close the inpatient burn unit at Brigham and Women's Hospital and combine it with a larger one at Mass. General Hospital. **D1.**

Governor Maura Healey warned of misinformation about the childhood vaccine schedule, especially with hepatitis B. **B1.**



Oh man, winter

Thursday: Temps plunge. High 39-44. Low 11-16.

Friday: Not quite as bad. High 26-31. Low 23-28.

High tide: 9:49 a.m., 10:30 p.m.

Sunrise: 6:57 Sunset: 4:12

Weather and Comics, D5-6.

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KEEPING THE FAITH FOR DETAINED PASTOR



JESSICA RINALDI/GLOBE STAFF

Ivy Branscomb, a member of Saints Tabernacle of Worship in Stow, said Ruzana Nehonde was like a second mother to her. "She was always empowering me," said Branscomb, who plans to become a doctor.

Ruzana Nehonde put down deep roots here but it wasn't enough. Her church says she's up for the test.

By Lea Skene
GLOBE STAFF

They assembled as usual Sunday morning and delivered an urgent prayer, a plea for mercy amid the second Trump administration's immigration crack-down.

The message was personal for members of Saints Tabernacle of Worship in Stow. Almost a month had passed since associate pastor Ruzana Nehonde was detained during a routine check-in with Immigration and Customs Enforcement.

Nehonde, 49, had no criminal record, an adult son with birthright citizenship, a pending



ANDREW VUSHE

In her role as pastor at the church, Nehonde has led prayer groups, delivered sermons, and organized church initiatives over the years.

green card application, and a long history of compliance with ICE supervision.

After almost three decades in Massachusetts, she was shipped to a detention facility in Louisiana, facing deportation to her native Zimbabwe.

Losing a leader has shaken her church community, a small nondenominational Christian congregation mostly made up of immigrant families from Africa and elsewhere.

Many said they have a deep understanding of Nehonde's experience: how she believed in the American dream, trusted in God, and still became a casualty of the president's mass deportation agenda. They're left wondering why the administration would target someone so faithful.

PASTOR, Page A10

Property taxes set to jump again

Wu sees another double-digit rise for homeowners

By Niki Griswold
GLOBE STAFF

Property taxes for single-family homes in Boston are poised to jump 13 percent, on average, for the coming year, the second double-digit increase in as many years for homeowners, Mayor Michelle Wu announced Wednesday.

The projected year-over-year spike would hit residents soon after the new year, and is steeper than the one announced for this year, an average of 10.4 percent for single-family homeowners.

Wu is also signaling leaner times may be coming for City Hall, telling department heads to prepare for a possible 2 percent reduction in their budgets for the next fiscal year and imposing an immediate delay on new hires, according to a letter she sent to the council on Wednesday.

The prospect of another tax increase for homeowners comes as Wu continues to battle the Legislature over a plan to ease the crunch by temporarily shifting more of the burden to commercial properties. But that effort has stalled on Beacon Hill after failing to pass last year amid a messy public dispute with Democrats in the Senate.

In a briefing with reporters Tuesday, Wu urged state lawmakers to take action on the legislation she refiled.

"Housing is the single biggest cost for our residents who are struggling with the cost of living in Boston. It's also the single biggest liability for our competitiveness across our economy in Massachusetts," Wu said. "This is something we can fix, and that we can take action to address."

Nearly three-quarters of Boston's operating budget is funded by property taxes.

PROPERTY TAXES, Page A10

'How do we move from a reactive model where we are only picking up cancers when they declare themselves?'

DR. BETSY O'DONNELL, Dana-Farber Cancer Institute

Experimental blood tests for cancer bring hope, skepticism

By Felice J. Freyer
GLOBE STAFF

"We have detected a significant cancer signal in your body."

Those harrowing words came over the phone to Karen Burns White last year while she was en route with friends to a jazz festival in Maryland. She had taken a blood test intended to detect multiple types of cancer early, part of a free pilot program offered by her insurer, and the results came in while she was in a car crowded with friends. She decided to just enjoy the festival.

The test, known as Galleri and made by California-based GRAIL, looks for fragments of

DNA from cancer cells that float in the bloodstream. It is one of two such tests on the market, with dozens more in the pipeline. None is yet FDA-approved or covered by insurance.

Many cancer doctors hope that such tests, which are sometimes called "liquid biopsies," will transform cancer care by detecting the earliest signs of malignancy, enabling treatment before the disease becomes deadly. They are part of an accelerating effort to find cancer earlier and earlier, through blood tests as well as new techniques and artificial intelligence.

The goal is to take the same

energy and skill that has been deployed to develop treatments for cancer and put it to work at finding cancer early enough to stop it in its tracks, said Dr. Betsy O'Donnell, director of the Multi-Cancer Early Detection Clinic at the Dana-Farber Cancer Institute.

"How do we move from a reactive model where we are only picking up cancers when they declare themselves?" she said. O'Donnell is leading a study of the Galleri test, recruiting 1,000 people at high risk for cancer.

Today, 70 percent of cancers have no screening test. People can be screened for cancers of the prostate, colon, breast, and

CANCER, Page A7



ERIN CLARK/GLOBE STAFF

A "liquid biopsy" gave Karen Burns White concerning news, and after more tests, she learned she had breast cancer.